



American science is rapidly shrinking

Shoestring budgets, smaller labs are the new reality under Trump

BY CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON, LYDIA SIDHOM AND SUSAN SVRLUGA

Every night, Katherine Burns wakes up in a sweat. It feels like the world is closing in on her.

Burns, 47, runs a laboratory at the University of Cincinnati College of Medicine focused on endometriosis, a stigmatized, poorly understood gynecologic disease. She's not just intrigued by the complex interplay of the immune system and hormones that drive endometriosis but is one of the millions of American women who have it, suffering years of misdiagnosis, blackout levels of pain and infertility.

She's haunted by a terrifying prospect: the end of her research.

President Donald Trump's administration rocked the American research enterprise over the last year with disruptions and changes to the historically reliable stream of federal funding that fueled its science preeminence. While courts and Congress have stopped some of the harshest cuts, fewer projects are moving forward. Labs such as the one Burns leads are running on fumes.

American science is shrinking.

A Washington Post analysis found that through March 31, halfway through this fiscal year, the number of competitive grants awarded by the National Institutes of Health is down by more than half compared with the same period last year. Biomedical funding has also undergone a shift, the analysis found, cutting the U.S. research footprint across nearly every major disease area — including fewer grants focused on women's health, cancer and mental health.

Overall, the NIH supported over 2,700 fewer scientific projects in fiscal 2025, about a 15 percent cut in the number of competitive grants compared with the previous fiscal year. In Burns's field, women's health, there was a 31 percent drop in the number of projects funded in 2025 that included the word "women," after

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"I understand people want their candy and they want their soda, but it's not building health, and the mission ... is to build health."

Utah state Rep. Kristen Chevrier (R), speaking about the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program



KATHRYN GAMBLE FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Marc Craig visits St. Mark Lutheran Church's Neighborhood Fridge in West Des Moines, Iowa, last month.

SNAP users face maze of new restrictions

BY RACHEL ROUBEIN

Across the country, retailers and low-income Americans are facing complex new rules overhauling what millions of people can buy with food stamps.

In Iowa, anti-hunger advocates recently sought to highlight how some cold sandwiches and granola bars may not qualify. In Idaho, legislators had attempted to clarify the state's candy ban, since it allows KitKats and Twix because they contain flour. And

Kennedy's bans on what can be purchased using food stamps is expanding

in some states, food stamp recipients said they were surprised to learn sports drinks and certain flavored fizzy waters are off-limits.

As Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. and his allies seek to tackle

the widespread rate of chronic diseases causing Americans to die earlier, they argue federal dollars shouldn't help people buy products increasingly linked to poor health and obesity. Trump administration officials have pushed states to bar the use of food stamps for soda and candy.

Yet rolling out the changes to the nation's largest food assistance program has led to a complicated, and at times counterintuitive, maze of new restrictions, according to more than

SEE SNAP ON A16

Educators alarmed by students 'speed running' online degrees

BY TODD WALLACK

It takes most college students at least four years to earn a bachelor's degree. Christie Williams finished in three months.

The North Carolina human resources executive spent two months racking up credits through web tutorials after work in 2024, then raced through 11

online classes at the University of Maine at Presque Isle in four weeks. Later that year, she went back to earn her master's — in just five weeks. The two degrees cost a total of just over \$4,000.

Since then, she has coached a thousand other students on how to speed through the state college, shaving off years and thousands of dollars from the usual cost of a

degree.

"Why wouldn't you do that?" Williams asked. "It's kind of a no-brainer if you know about it."

Many U.S. schools have been experimenting with ways to speed up traditional college programs to reduce the burgeoning cost and help students move into the workforce faster. Some offer three-year bachelor's programs,

reducing the number of credits needed for a diploma by one quarter. Many more allow students to enroll in college classes while still in high school.

But the breakneck pace of the fastest online programs concerns some academics, who say there is a big difference in what students can learn in weeks or months

SEE COLLEGE ON A6

Police: Eight kids killed in Louisiana shooting

Most of the victims were the gunman's children, Shreveport officials say

BY MARIANA ALFARO AND CHRIS HACKER

Eight children ranging in age from 1 to about 14 were killed Sunday in a shooting in Shreveport, Louisiana, that police described as a domestic disturbance. It was the deadliest mass killing in the United States in two years, data shows.

A spokesman for the Shreveport police, Chris Bordelon, told reporters on Sunday that seven of the children were believed to be "descendants of the gunman" and that two other victims survived. "This is an extensive scene unlike anything most of us have ever seen," Bordelon said.

Later Sunday, police identified the gunman as Shamar Elkins. Public records show that Elkins was a 31-year-old Shreveport resident. Elkins served in the Louisiana Army National Guard from August 2013 to August 2020, according to an Army statement. He did not deploy while with the National Guard and left the Army as a private, an entry-level rank.

The gunman, the spokesman said, stole a car after the shootings, leading to a police chase into neighboring Bossier City that ended with his death. The Louisiana State Police are investigating Elkins's killing.

Bordelon said officers responded to a report of a shooting just after 6 a.m. and that the crime scene spread across four locations: three residences and the area where the gunman died. The shooting was domestic in nature, he said, and the gunman was an adult. No motive

SEE LOUISIANA ON A7



GERALD HERBERT/AP

People grieve outside the scene of a shooting Sunday that Shreveport police spokesman Chris Bordelon described as domestic in nature. The gunman led police on a chase that ended with his death.

Trump: Iranian vessel seized

CLAIMS SHIP TRIED TO RUN BLOCKADE

Talks set to resume amid president's threats

BY MARIANA ALFARO, TARA COPP, JOYCE SOHYUN LEE AND SAMMY WESTFALL

President Donald Trump said Sunday that the U.S. military seized an Iranian-flagged cargo ship that tried to bypass the American blockade of the vital Strait of Hormuz, hours after he renewed his threats of broad attacks on Iran's infrastructure if no deal is reached in talks expected this week in Pakistan.

"The U.S. Navy Guided Missile Destroyer USS SPRUANCE intercepted the TOUNSKA in the Gulf of Oman, and gave them fair warning to stop," Trump wrote in a Truth Social post. "The Iranian crew refused to listen, so our Navy ship stopped them right in their tracks by blowing a hole in the engine room. Right now, U.S. Marines have custody of the vessel."

The operation marks the first ship boarding by U.S. forces since the naval blockade took effect April 13, as part of Trump's effort to exert pressure on Tehran. As of Sunday, 25 vessels have been turned back due to the blockade, including the Tounska, said U.S. Central Command, which oversees military operations in the Middle East.

SEE IRAN ON A11

World Bank, IMF realign with Trump administration

BY DAVID J. LYNCH

One year after Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent publicly blasted the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank for deviating from their core missions in favor of trendier pursuits, the two global bodies have worked their way back into the "America First" administration's good graces.

Other multilateral institutions, including the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), remain targets for President Donald Trump's slashing social media posts. But the two financial organizations have avoided the president's ire by adapting to his demands, an evolution that was on display last week during the annual spring meetings of the IMF and World Bank.

The turnaround is striking. In an April 2025 speech, Bessent assailed the fund for dabbling in "climate change, gender and social issues" rather than monitoring the global economy, and accused the bank of pursuing "vapid, buzzword-centric" initiatives.

Bessent last week struck a much different tone speaking to a financial industry group, saying both institutions were back on track. The shift illustrates the malleable contours of Trump's brand of economic nationalism. Normally allergic to anything that

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